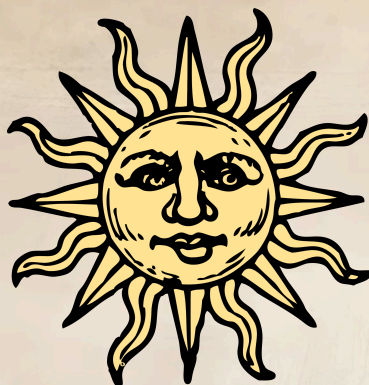




FACTIONS & RUMORS

A GM-TOOLKIT FOR DRAGONBANE ADVENTURES

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LAYOUT:

This game supplement was created using the DragonBrew homebrewery template.

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HUMAN MADE

hinokodo.itch.io/human-made

MADE WITH:



THE HOMEBREWERY

Homebrewery.Naturalcrit.com



STRUCTURE OF THE WORLD

The basic features of an adventure setting can be categorized into geographic dimensions, measures of time, factions, meta-plot, encounters, and so on. The following pages provide descriptions and guidelines on how to create, structure and run these for a procedural adventure setting that still has that specific Dragonbane feeling to it.

SPACIAL DIMENSIONS

The basic geographic structure of an adventure setting can be divided into regions, areas, adventure sites, and locations – ordered from largest to smallest (See below).

MEASURING TIME

In addition to the normal three units of time, this supplement introduces 2 additional units to measure longer durations. A **FEWNIGHT** is about the time required to travel to and from an adventure site and to plan and resolve faction missions.

UNIT

OF TIME

DURATION

ENOUGH TIME TO...

Fewnights

4~8 days

Play through an adventure site, resolve a faction mission.

Month

~90 days

Heal severe injuries, resolve a long-term faction mission.

GEOGRAPHY

REGIONS

A region is the largest mechanically relevant place and encompasses several areas and adventure sites. The large maps included in official adventures depict regions – with the exception of Arkand (see below).

The purpose of a region is to structure the geographical layout of an adventure. It is further sub-divided into areas which hold individual adventure sites. Each region typically contains an over-arching plot that is played out in the various adventure sites, and a number of factions active in the region, that can be encountered frequently.

ALTERNATE SCALES

SMALLER THAN A REGION: If it does not make sense to divide an adventure setting into multiple areas – if it takes place in a large city like Arkand or the dwarven mines of the Gates of Power (Path of Glory) – it can simply consist of a single area without defining a full region.

MULTIPLE REGIONS: A larger adventure setting can feature multiple regions. In this case, each region should still have its distinct overarching plot and distinct factions to warrant the separation into regions. It should also be made clear how the regions connect, by what means of transport the party can get from one to the other, and how long it takes them to get there.

AREAS

Map areas are places within a region that are unified by a similar landscape, vegetation and general vibe or feeling.

Areas structure a group's journey through the region. An area is typically large enough to take a couple of shifts of travel to fully cross, but can easily take several days. Each area has its own random encounters table, that determines what you might discover while traveling through it.

ADVENTURE SITES

Adventure sites are smaller-scale places that encompass a self-contained part of an adventure, like a village, a dungeon or a sinister castle. An adventure site is typically the goal of a journey and the main place where an adventure takes place.

An adventure site is comprised of multiple locations that are typically numbered on an overview map of the site, so that players can get a sense of orientation. An adventure site also typically has a random events table.

LOCATIONS

Locations are the single rooms, halls, courtyards and other spaces that make up the adventure site. The location descriptions should indicate where random events can occur, where treasure is hidden, and which monsters or NPCs are present, and what exits lead to other locations. For each full stretch the PCs spend in a location, the GM can roll on the adventure site's random events table or select a suitable event.

THE META-PLOT

The meta-plot is the big thing that is currently going on in the region. It is what generates the conflict between the factions. A fight for control of the region – like the search for a powerful artifact, struggle for power, or conflicting ideas on how to deal with a common threat.

FACTION GOALS

The meta-plot determines the goals of a faction in the region. Factions can have larger goals, like re-establishing the empire, that transcend their regional goals. But the goals relevant for play are about what they seek in this region – like searching for the ancient crown.

Factions can have completely asymmetric goals that nonetheless come into conflict with each other. An example would be the druid circle that wants to heal nature and the settlers fleeing from a war trying to tame the land to settle here.

PLOT PROGRESS

A good meta-plot should have a simple way to measure the player character's and faction's progress towards their goals. This can be the number of keys gathered, proportion of strategically important sites conquered, number of villages liberated, or something similar.

EXAMPLE META-PLOTS

HUNT FOR THE KEYS

The most used meta-plot in Dragonbane adventures so far has been factions looking for parts of a key to a powerful artifact. In this meta-plot, the different factions all have the same primary goal: to find the keys and get the artifact first.

A GAME OF THRONES

A more subtle meta-plot is different factions competing for power over the region – ordering assassinations, stealing secrets, and even engaging in small skirmishes. In this scenario, factions either have the goal to gain power or prevent others from gaining it, and tend to use different methods – either subterfuge or overt force.

ALL-OUT WAR

The most terrible type of conflict between factions is an all-out war. The goal of factions engaged in war have the goal of destroying each other. A war can also break out between political factions vying for power when court intrigue and proxy-battles are no longer effective.

THE HUB

It is always good to have a regional hub – like Outskirt (in the Core Set Adventures) – a camp, village or town where the player characters can rest safely, buy and sell gear, and hear the latest rumors about adventure sites.

RUMORS

The regional hub is where player characters can hear rumors. That is why a hub has a Rumors Table. Each rumor should point the player characters to an adventure site or to a place in town, where an adventure scenario takes place.

FACTION RUMORS: When factions start missions, people will notice and talk about what they saw or heard. This gossip can then be added to the rumor table. A rumor about a faction mission should not reveal the mission's goal, but should alert the player characters that something is going on in an adventure site.

BACKDROP

Beside the main factions in the adventure, there are many other communities, monsters, bandits, or other beings who dwell in the region and have their own habits and interests.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Each area of a region has its own random encounter table. Such a table contains not only combat encounters with monsters and bandits, but also interesting landmarks or the area, sightings of awe-inspiring beasts, or chance encounters with friendly NPCs.

BACKDROP RUMORS: Some rumors have nothing to do with faction activities, but are about other things going on in the region – like ancient ruins bearing treasure, a local community or tribe who are wary but not necessarily hostile towards the player characters, or a monster that has recently attacked a farm or merchant.

FACTIONS

“When you play the game of thrones, you win or you die. There is no middle ground.”

– GEORGE R.R. MARTIN, A GAME OF THRONES

Factions are groups of NPCs who have interests that can align with or come into conflict with those of the player characters. In a typical Dragonbane adventure, you should have at least three factions major with conflicting goals and methods. Their struggle for control and victory generates a dynamic background to your ongoing adventure setting.

FACTION REPUTATION

You can use the reputation rules to track the PCs standing with each of the factions. Directly aiding or interfering with a faction mission counts as an extraordinary deed.

FACTION FEATURES

Factions have **GOALS** they want to achieve, for which they deploy **UNITS** and **ASSETS** in a settlement or to one of the major adventure sites in the region.

GOALS: A faction has one or two specific overall goals in the setting that informs all their activities in the region.

MISSIONS: A faction undertakes missions to enhance their power or progress towards their goals. Typical missions include: recruiting new agents and underlings; searching new assets in adventure sites; increasing their power in a settlement; or attacking a rival faction.

UNITS: The most visible part of a faction are the units they send on missions. There are two types of units: **AGENTS**, like knights or spies, work alone; **GROUPS** include about four to six low-raknig faction members.

ASSETS: Factions own real estate, wealth, tamed monsters or powerful magic items to further their goals. Assets can't do anything on their own but must be used by a faction unit on a mission.

FACTION MISSIONS

SETTING UP MISSIONS

Factions undertake missions to further their goals. Set up new missions and resolve ongoing missions between sessions so that the world changes once the PCs return to a settlement from an adventure site.

To set up a mission, the faction must have a free **UNIT** to assign to it. Missions aim to further a faction's goals, like acquiring assets, attacking an enemy, recruiting more units, or opposing a rival faction's mission.

RUMORS TABLE: Unless a faction deploys a secret agent, a faction mission adds an entry to the rumors table or card deck available to the players – something like “The brotherhood is searching for an ancient temple in the Thornwood” or “The thieves guild is recruiting again”.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS: If a faction sends their units to an adventure site, they can be encountered during travel in the area, if they keep guard posts or patrols in the surrounding area, or when they are still searching for a well-hidden adventure site. Decide whether they are generally hostile, neutral or friendly towards the PCs.

ADVENTURE STIES: If a faction mission sends a unit to an adventure site, it takes a certain amount of time to com-

plete. A simple mission only takes up to a week; More complex missions can take several weeks, during which time the units will be present at the site and can be helped or hindered by the PCs or another faction's units.

RESOLVING MISSIONS

Before setting up new missions between sessions, check whether any ongoing missions are about to end. If player characters were involved in an ongoing mission, whether it succeeds or fails is resolved during play. The faction gains or loses **UNIT** or **ASSET** accordingly.

If the PCs are not involved in a mission, roll on the highest relevant skill rating among all involved **UNITS**:

- ♦ If the roll succeeds, the mission is successful. Depending on the pursued **GOAL**, the faction also gains a new **UNIT** or **ASSET**.
- ♦ If the roll fails, the mission fails or had to be aborted.
- ♦ If a rival faction opposes the mission, resolve both sides with an open opposed roll, only the winning side succeeds in their mission.
- ♦ On a dragon, the winning faction gains an extra reward, but on a demon, one of the **UNITS** or **ASSETS** in play is lost or killed during the mission.

EXAMPLE FACTIONS

RULE OF THREE

You can use the “the good, the bad, and the ugly” rule of thumb to create the major three factions in your adventure setting:

THE GOOD: A self-righteous faction, like a knights’ order or religious institution that seeks to spread law and order. However, their “goodness” can be questionable.

THE BAD: A chaotic faction that uses stealth and subterfuge to achieve its selfish and power-hungry ambitions. They can be allied to the PCs but will likely betray them.

THE UGLY: This faction can be any wild or untamable horde, like a nightkin clan, barbarian tribe or band of pirates. To ally with them, the PCs must first prove themselves.



KNIGHTS ORDER OF THE CLEANSING FIRE

Another offshoot of the Keepers of the Immaculate Flame, these knights see themselves as the only true heirs to the ancient dragon knights of emperor Eledain. The order stands for the cleansing of the corrupted with fire and sword, and adhere to strict codes of purity, truth, duty, and order. They too seek to re-establish Eledain’s empire, but hold that the other sects of self-proclaimed dragon knights have fallen off the one true path. They have adopted Eledain’s all-seeing eye surrounded by pure flame as their symbol.

GOAL: Their primary goal is to oppose the machinations of the demon prince Beliel in the south and hunt his followers and cultists with a fierce determination.

UNITS: The three dragon knights Thorfinn, Mereniel and Herderik (**AGENTS**); Hired adventurers (**GROUP**)

ASSETS: An ancient longsword, warhammer, and morn-ingstar that all glow when demons are nearby

MISSIONS:

- ◆ Recruit squires or hire mercenaries (+**GROUP**)
- ◆ Uncover ancient dragon empire artefacts (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Bring cultists **GROUPS** or **AGENTS** to swift justice



BELIEL CULTISTS

The demon prince Beliel is the incarnation of malice, cruelty, deception, lies, selfishness, corruption, and the achievement of power over others. He hails from a demonic realm of madness and chaos. Beliel’s worshippers wear his demonic mark branded somewhere on their body, usually on their forearm hidden under their clothes. The mark is a stylized depiction of Beliel’s twisted horns.

GOAL: Beliel seeks to enter the mortal world to dominate its inhabitants and so expand his domain.

UNITS: The demon cultists (**GROUP**); The secret agent Mara – aka “Alina” (**AGENT**); Shell the assassin (**AGENT**)

ASSETS: Demonic messenger bats; A ritual to summon a demon (**SUMMON CHAMPION**, Book of Magic p.32)

MISSIONS:

- ◆ Recruit ordinary villagers into the cult (+**GROUP**)
- ◆ Find powerful magic spells and items (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Covertly assassinate a rival faction **AGENT**



THE NIGHTKIN HORDE

A mighty orc chieftain Harkar has united the orcs, goblins, hobgoblins and even a few ogres under her banner. This horde stands for freedom, independence, the law of the blade, rule of the strong and the wild pride of the various nightkins. They rally under Harkar’s flag of the double slashed scar.

GOAL: The nightkin seek to drive out the “daykin” – especially humans and halflings – out of their ancestral lands. They see them as squatters and trespassers.

UNITS: Goblin scouts (**GROUP**); Orc warriors (**GROUP**); The orcish shaman Karakmûl (**AGENT**); The ogre twins Mog and Mrak (**AGENTS**)

ASSETS: A war camp hidden in a densely wooded mountain valley; A small pack of riding worgs

MISSIONS:

- ◆ Raise a champion among the ranks (+**AGENT**)
- ◆ Raid a nearby daykin farm or village (+**ASSET**)
- ◆ Defeat a daykin **GROUP** or **AGENT** in combat

AREA NAME:

Map areas are places within a region that are unified by a similar landscape, vegetation and general vibe or feeling.

Areas have the following features:

- ✦ Areas structure a group's journey through the region.
- ✦ An area is typically large enough to take cross in a couple of shifts, but can take up to a couple of days.
- ✦ Each area has its own Random Encounters table for what you discover while traveling through it.

ADVENTURE SITES

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Roll on a Random Encounters table about every shift.

✦ Or simply select a suitable encounter instead of rolling.

D12 EVENT

1-6 **NOTHING HAPPENS.**

7

8

9

10

11

12